THE EXACT METHOD · FREE GUIDE

The Video Brief

Tell AI exactly how to make your video, then check what it gives you. The setup, the brief, the checks and the skills that keep AI video from looking AI-made.

A free, standalone guide. Set it up once, and every video after that starts from a script, voice files and one written brief.

01 What This File Does

This guide shows how to make short vertical videos (Reels, Shorts, TikToks) by giving Claude a script, voice files and a written brief. Claude builds the video in code, renders it, checks it and sends you the file. You never open an editing app.

You don't need to know how to code. Claude writes and runs it. Your job is to describe the video precisely and judge the result. That's the work that makes it your video and not a template.

The guide has five parts: the setup (sections 02 to 05), the brief and the prompts (06 to 09), the checks (10), the skills and plugins that keep the result from looking AI-made (11 to 14), and two outside sources: reference videos to borrow motion from, and AI footage made from inside Claude (15 and 16).

How to use it, in three steps: do the setup once, fill in the brief for each video, then send the three prompts in order and review what comes back.

02 What You Need

WHAT	WHAT IT DOES	COST, AS OF NOVEMBER 2026
Claude with Claude Code	Writes the video as code, renders it and checks the render	Included in the Pro, Max and Ultra plans
Remotion	Turns the code into an MP4 file	Free for individuals and for companies of three people or fewer. Larger companies need a Company License, from $25 a month per person writing Remotion code
ffmpeg	Handles audio, loudness, cutting and export	Free
ElevenLabs	Makes the voiceover	Starter plan: $6 a month for 30,000 credits
Higgsfield (optional)	Makes AI footage and images from inside Claude	A paid plan is needed to use it from Claude. Plans start at $9 a month for 120 credits (October 2026)

Claude installs Remotion and ffmpeg itself (section 05). You only need two accounts: Claude and ElevenLabs. Higgsfield is only for videos that use AI footage (section 16).

03 The Voice: License and Cost

ElevenLabs' free plan has no commercial license. Their help center says it directly: "The free plan does not include a commercial license and cannot be used for any commercial purpose." Audio from the free plan that you publish also has to credit ElevenLabs.

If your videos promote anything you sell (a product, a service, your own business), that's commercial use, so you need a paid plan.

In practice it costs very little. The Starter plan is $6 a month, includes the commercial license and comes with 30,000 credits. On the Eleven v4 model one character of script costs one credit, and a 45-second Reel script runs about 600 to 1,000 characters. That makes 30,000 credits enough for more than 30 Reels a month.

04 Connecting ElevenLabs to Claude

Claude makes the voice files through an API key. A restricted key can only do what you allow and only spend what you allow, so set it up this way.

Create the key

1. Go to elevenlabs.io/app/developers/api-keys and click Create API key.
2. Name it, for example claude-voiceovers.
3. Turn on Restrict Key.
4. Set a credit limit below your plan's total, for example 20,000 on Starter. The rest stays free for anything you make by hand.
5. Under Endpoints, set Text to Speech to Access, Voices to Read and Models to Access. Leave every other endpoint on No Access.
6. Leave Restrict by IP address off. Cloud workspaces change their address, and the key would stop working.
7. Keep Auto-disable if leaked on.
8. Click Create Key and copy the key. ElevenLabs shows it only once.

Copy the voice IDs

Open Voices, then My Voices. Click the three dots next to each voice you use and choose Copy voice ID. Note which voice belongs to which speaker, plus the settings you use for each: model, stability and similarity.

Hand it to Claude

PROMPT · HAND OVER THE KEY

Save this ElevenLabs API key and these voice IDs in a private settings file that only you read. Never put the key in a command, a log or a message.

API key: [paste]
[Speaker 1] voice ID: [paste]
[Speaker 2] voice ID: [paste]
Model: [for example eleven_v4]. Stability: [for example 0.5]. Similarity: [for example 0.75].

Whenever you make a voice file, also save its word timings (ElevenLabs returns them with the audio), so every cue can land on its word.

Then test it: confirm both voices exist on my account, make one short line in each voice and send me the two files.

If both test files sound right, the setup is finished. From then on a full voiceover takes one sentence from you.

Two things can go wrong here. If Claude reports that it can't reach ElevenLabs, its workspace is blocking the connection: open Settings, then Capabilities, turn on Allow network egress, wait a minute and ask Claude to try again. And a key you paste into a chat stays in that chat's history, which is why the restrictions and the credit limit matter. You can delete the key in ElevenLabs at any time and create a new one with the same settings.

05 The Setup Prompt

Send this once, in the same workspace you'll make videos in.

PROMPT · SETUP

Set up this workspace for making vertical videos with Remotion.

First, check for a Node.js version the current Remotion supports, plus ffmpeg and ffprobe. Install anything missing and tell me what you installed.

Then create a blank Remotion project for 1080x1920 video at 30 fps. Render a two-second test video with one line of text, and confirm the file plays and is 1080x1920 at 30 fps. If Remotion can't download its browser for rendering, use a Chromium that is already installed instead.

Finally, tell me in a few lines what is ready and what still needs me.

Run it once per workspace. If the workspace resets, run it again.

06 Why "Make Me a Cool Video" Gets a Template

Leave a blank, and AI fills it with its default. Ask for "a cool video" and every blank gets one: the font, the colours, the way text appears, the pacing, the ending. Defaults are what AI-made videos share, and that's why so many of them look the same.

A better tool won't fix this. Fewer blanks will.

It's the same idea behind all of The Exact Method: say exactly what you want, then check what you get. For video, saying exactly what you want is the brief in section 07. Checking is the review in section 10.

07 The Brief

Fill this in once per video. Send it together with the voice files, or put both in the project folder and tell Claude where they are.

TEMPLATE · THE BRIEF

Goal and viewer. Who it's for, in one line: [for example, people who use ChatGPT for everyday decisions]. What they should do after watching: [for example, get the free PDF from the bio].

Script. One line per voice file: [file name] · [speaker] · [the exact line]. Words that must appear on screen: [list them exactly, or write "your choice"].

Look. Colours as hex codes: background [ ], text [ ], accent [ ], mistakes [ ]. Fonts, by name: headlines [ ], body [ ]. References: [two or three frames or videos, and what to take from each].

Timing. Time everything to the real voice files, never to an estimate. Pauses: [for example 0.3 s between lines, 0.5 s before the call to action]. Hold the last frame [about 1 s] after the last word.

Never. [for example: nothing covers the presenter's hand; no text over busy screen text; no stretch of empty screen; no drop shadows, glows or bouncing text; nothing that appears in a single frame; "link in bio" never as plain text].

Export. 1080x1920, 30 fps, voice at about -14 LUFS, peaks under -1 dB.

Each block closes a blank. The never-list does the most work: it's where your taste goes.

Each block exists because leaving it out causes a specific problem:

- Without an export block, a video can go out at 720x1280 with the voice at -20 LUFS, quieter than everything around it in the feed.
- Without a timing rule, captions drift. Half a second late is enough to feel wrong.
- Without a never-list, the AI places elements wherever there's space, including on top of a character's hand.

08 Prompt 1: From Brief to Storyboard

PROMPT · BRIEF TO STORYBOARD

Here's my brief. Before building anything, write a storyboard: one row per shot, with start and end times taken from the real lengths of the voice files; what's on screen and how it enters and leaves; and one sentence per shot on why it is there at that moment.

Check every shot against the never-list. If anything in the brief is unclear, ask instead of guessing. Don't build anything until I approve the storyboard.

Read the "why" column first. A shot that can't say why it's there is usually filler.

09 Prompt 2: Build, Render, Check

PROMPT · BUILD AND CHECK

The storyboard is approved. Build the video in Remotion.

Time every cue to the word it belongs to, using the word timings. Before the full render, render stills of the three busiest moments and check them against the never-list. Fix anything that fails, then render the full video.

After the render, check it yourself before you show me: the timing against the voice at every cut; any frame that pops, flashes or goes black, including frame-by-frame sheets around every moment something appears; empty stretches, overlaps and cut-off text; the loudness and the resolution.

Send me the video, a contact sheet of frames and a short list of what you checked and what you fixed.

Stills first saves time. A full render takes minutes, and a still shows most problems in seconds.

10 The Eight Checks, and the Fix Message

Watch every render on your phone, once with sound and once without, and check these eight things.

CHECK	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Timing	Every caption and card lands on its word, not after it
Dead time	Any pause where nothing moves and nobody speaks
Overlaps	Text or cards on top of a face, a hand or other text
Empty space	Large areas with nothing in them, especially at the end
The first three seconds	The hook works with the sound off
Readability	Small text that's fine on a laptop and unreadable on a phone
Loudness	About -14 LUFS. Quieter voices sound weak next to other videos
Resolution	1080x1920 at 30 fps

With the skills in section 13 installed, Claude runs most of these checks before you watch. Automatic pop scans catch large jumps; a small element that appears in one frame (a strike-through, an underline) can slip past them. That's what frame-by-frame sheets around each cue are for.

Prompt 3: the fix message

Vague feedback gets you a guess. Precise feedback gets you a fix.

VAGUE	PRECISE
"Make it better."	"0:22: the card covers the presenter's hand. Move the cards up so the hand is clear."
"The ending drags."	"The end card holds for about 7 s. Cut it to 1 s after the last word."
"Fix the captions."	"From 0:19 the captions are about 0.5 s late. Time them to the word timestamps."

The pattern is the same every time: where it happens (the timestamp), what is wrong, and what to do instead. Put every note in one message so Claude fixes them all in one pass.

11 Skills and Plugins, Explained

A skill is a folder of instructions Claude loads for one kind of job, such as building in Remotion, avoiding certain visual habits or checking a render. A plugin bundles several skills, sometimes with tools.

Without them, Claude falls back on its defaults, and that's where AI slop comes from. With them, it follows rules someone's already tested on real videos.

PROMPT · INSTALL A SKILL

Install this skill from [GitHub link] into ~/.claude/skills/. Before you install anything, read its README and SKILL.md and tell me in one line whether anything looks unsafe or needs an API key. Install only the parts I name.

You can install part of a repository. Many contain several skills and you may need only one or two.

A skill is someone else's instructions, and often someone else's code. Read what it does before it runs, and check the license: some free skills forbid commercial use.

12 The Core Skills

These handle the building and the planning.

SKILL	WHAT IT DOES	WHERE TO GET IT
Remotion skills (official)	How to build, animate, caption and render in Remotion. Maintained by the Remotion team, about 6,500 GitHub stars	github.com/remotion-dev/skills
ffmpeg-llm	Accurate ffmpeg commands for audio, cutting, loudness and export, plus an ffmpeg troubleshooting agent	github.com/rendi-api/ffmpeg-llm
storyboard-architect	Turns a brief into a shot list with timing, on-screen text and a reason for every shot, then validates it	github.com/whystrohm/shotkit
brand-lock-extractor	Turns your colours, fonts and visual rules into one brand file that every video follows	github.com/whystrohm/shotkit
content-principles	The psychology of short-form scripts: one viewer, every line earning the next, specific words over vague ones	github.com/aiwithremy/content-principles
watch	Lets Claude watch a video from a link or a file, through frames and a transcript. Useful for studying videos you want to learn from	github.com/bradautomates/claude-video

shotkit contains five skills. storyboard-architect and brand-lock-extractor are the two that matter for this workflow.

13 The Anti-Slop Toolkit

"AI slop" is the look people now recognise in a second: shadows on every box, text that pops in, glowing gradients, slides that never move. These skills exist to remove it. They work in different ways, so they're worth combining.

no-slop-motion

github.com/ferndesk/no-slop-motion

A banned list, standing rules and a step-by-step approval process for animated videos. Its scripts scan a render for pops, flashes and black frames, and make contact sheets of frames for review. The rules work with any engine; its own build tools use HyperFrames (section 14).

Its default banned list, in plain words:

1. Drop shadows on boxes and cards. Only buttons get depth.
2. Glows, round colour gradients, dark frame edges and coloured "world" backgrounds.
3. Grids of cards or lists of icons in place of an actual explanation.
4. A screen that just sits there with nothing moving, like a slide.
5. Text parked at the top of the frame while the action happens below.
6. Anything that appears, vanishes or flashes within one or two frames, and cuts to black between shots.
7. Glitch and shader transitions picked for "energy".
8. Movement at a constant speed, and bouncy overshoot on interface elements.
9. Colour filters that fake a look in place of chosen colours.
10. Customer quotes shown as tweet or chat screenshots.
11. More than one call-to-action button in the brand colour in one frame.
12. A sound effect on every landing.
13. A voice stitched together from one-line clips, or cut in the middle of a word.

Impeccable

github.com/pbakaus/impeccable

The most widely used design-quality skill, with about 105,000 GitHub stars. Its slop detector applies 62 fixed rules to flag the usual AI design habits and needs no API key. It also has critique and audit commands that rank what to fix first. It's built for interfaces, so it suits the look of scenes built from web code (Remotion and HyperFrames scenes are), not timing or editing.

claude-motion-design

github.com/howseen-ai/claude-motion-design

Motion design in plain code (HTML, Playwright and ffmpeg) with no Remotion license. You approve four stills before the full render, and a pop scan runs after it. About 790 stars. A security-graded skills directory flags that it installs packages while it runs, so read what it installs first.

Claude Video 2.0

github.com/ItssssJack/claude-video-2

You pick one of 21 visual styles from a gallery and answer five questions. It shows three stills for approval, renders, then checks its own frames. MIT license. Optional AI clips use a paid Higgsfield key.

video-use

github.com/browser-use/video-use

Made for raw footage, not animation. It cuts filler words and dead space, adds 30-millisecond audio fades so cuts never click, and checks every cut in the render before showing you anything. MIT license. It needs an ElevenLabs key, which it uses for transcription.

14 More Proven Skills

SKILL	WHAT IT IS	WHERE TO GET IT
HyperFrames (HeyGen)	An open-source engine that turns HTML and animation into MP4, built for AI agents. Apache 2.0 license, no per-render fees	github.com/heygen-com/hyperframes
IT Reelsmaker	For talking-head footage: cuts pauses and retakes by the audio, adds word-timed subtitles, keeps text off faces and masters the sound to -14 LUFS	github.com/itpartypattaya/reels-montage
claude-code-video-toolkit	A complete video workspace covering script, voiceover, music, visuals and render. MIT license	github.com/digitalsamba/claude-code-video-toolkit
/brag	Turns a project you built into a short launch video with music and share copy	github.com/latent-spaces/brag
apple-design	A design review grounded in Apple's Human Interface Guidelines, with a check for templated looks	github.com/dickwu/apple-design-skill

Check the license before you use these two commercially. video-editor-skills (editing in DaVinci Resolve) uses CC BY-NC 4.0, which rules out commercial use. motion-graphics-skills has a strong banned list but is published as "All Rights Reserved".

To browse further, agentskillshub.top keeps a list of 430 video skills, security-graded and re-checked daily.

15 Reference Videos: Prompt Motion

The hardest part of the brief to put into words is the motion: how things enter, move and leave. "Smooth" or "dynamic" leaves a blank, and Claude fills it with its default. A reference video closes that blank.

prompt-motion.com is a free gallery of motion videos made with Claude, each shown with the prompt or skill behind it. You can filter by type (Product UI, Phone, Charts, Kinetic type, Diagrams and more), and every entry links to the person who made it.

How to borrow a reference

1. Pick a video for its motion, not for its colours or its brand.
2. Record your screen while it plays and send the recording to Claude. Claude studies a video through its frames, and the watch skill in section 12 helps.
3. Send the prompt below.
4. Keep the result as a reference video. Every later video that uses this animation starts from it, so your look stays the same from video to video.

PROMPT · REBUILD A REFERENCE

Here is a screen recording of a reference video. First, list every motion and feature in it, in order, with rough timings: how each element enters, moves and leaves, and every transition. Then rebuild it as a short reference video in my brief's colours, fonts and words. Copy the idea, the motion and the pace. Don't copy the colours, the shapes, the brand or the text. Check the remake against my never-list and replace anything on it.

Ask for the list first and check it. Anything missing from the list will be missing from the remake.

Two cautions. Videos and prompts belong to their creators, so borrow the motion, leave the rest of their work alone, and credit the creator if you share their prompt. And popular entries often use habits from the banned list in section 13, such as letter-by-letter typing or glows. Your never-list decides what stays.

16 AI Footage Inside Claude: Higgsfield

Remotion draws everything with code: text, shapes, layouts, screens. It can't film a person, a product on a table or a street at night. Higgsfield can generate that. It's a paid platform with many image and video models (Kling, Seedance, Veo and Nano Banana among them), and its connector lets Claude use them from the chat: Claude picks a model, sets it up, makes the clip and shows it to you.

Use it for the shots code can't draw, and keep code for everything else: text, captions, timing and the end card. The clip goes into the Remotion project like any other video file.

Connect it

1. In Claude, open Settings, then Connectors, and click Add custom connector.
2. Name it Higgsfield and paste this address: https://mcp.higgsfield.ai/mcp
3. Click Connect, sign in to Higgsfield and approve access.
4. In Claude Code, run these three commands instead: npm i -g @higgsfield/cli, then higgsfield auth login, then npx skills add higgsfield-ai/skills.

What it costs

You need an active paid Higgsfield plan. Every clip Claude makes spends credits. The unlimited offers on Higgsfield's website don't apply to clips made through Claude. As of October 2026, plans start at $9 a month for 120 credits. A 5-second Kling 3.0 clip costs about 8 credits, and a 4-second Veo 3.1 clip about 40. Prices changed several times in 2026, so check the pricing page before you pick a plan.

There's no hard spending limit for Claude. You can name a limit in your prompt, but Claude can still go over it, so the prompt on the next page makes Claude ask before it spends anything.

Ask before it spends

PROMPT · ONE AI CLIP

Using Higgsfield, make one [5]-second vertical clip: [the shot: subject, setting, camera, light]. Before you make anything, tell me which model you'll use, the settings and the credit cost, and wait for my yes. Stay under [N] credits in this chat. Then add the clip to the video at [timestamp] and run the eight checks again.

Describe the shot like a camera operator would: what's in frame, where the camera is, how it moves, what the light is like.

Before you post a clip

- License. The free plan has restricted commercial rights. Check Higgsfield's terms for your plan before you use a clip in a video that sells something.
- Files. Claude can't pass files from the chat to Higgsfield. Upload reference images in Higgsfield, or give Claude a direct link.
- Checks. AI footage gets the same eight checks as everything else, plus one more: look for warped hands, faces and lettering in every clip.
- Labels. Platforms have rules for labelling AI-made footage. Check the rule where you post.

17 What This Won't Do

It won't give you taste. Claude follows the brief and the rules; whether the result is good is your call.

It can't catch what it doesn't check, so ask for the contact sheet and the check list with every render.

Skills are other people's work. Read them before you install them and check their licenses. The same goes for reference videos and their prompts.

A reference video or an AI clip won't save a weak script.

A precise brief makes a better video. It doesn't guarantee views.

If You Want the Rest of the System

The Video Brief applies one idea to one job: precise input, then a careful check of the output. The Exact Method teaches that idea in full, across coding, content, e-commerce, freelancing and design, from the first prompt to the final check, and gives video its own chapter.

Where to find the full guide: *theexactmethod.com*

Sources, checked November 2026: ElevenLabs pricing page and help center ("Can I publish the content I generate on the platform?"); ElevenLabs API authentication docs; Claude Help Center ("Use Claude Code with your Pro, Max or Ultra plan" and "Create and edit files with Claude"); Remotion license FAQ and Agent Skills docs; star-history.com for Impeccable; agentskillshub.top for remotion-dev/skills and claude-motion-design; prompt-motion.com; Higgsfield help center ("How to Connect Higgsfield to Claude or ChatGPT") and blog ("How to Generate AI Videos in Claude With the Higgsfield MCP Connector"); Higgsfield plan prices and credit costs as reported by AI Eating the World ("Higgsfield AI Pricing", October 2026).